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WS Global CIO Office
17 April 2026

Weekly Market View

Full circle

→ Global equities have recovered losses suffered during the Middle East conflict on hopes of a resolution.

→ The recovery in risk assets once again highlights the importance of staying invested through geopolitical crises, as long as fundamentals don't change significantly. If the US-Iran truce holds, we expect strong US earnings to drive the next leg of the rally.

→ US Q1 bank earnings have beaten expectations, reflecting resilient macro fundamentals. We prefer the US technology and utilities equity sectors which are likely to report strong revenue and earnings on the back of soaring AI-related demand.

→ We also expect the USD to continue its downtrend, after a brief period of consolidation, amid expectations of policy divergence between a neutral-to-dovish Fed and hawkish other major central banks such as the ECB, BoJ and BoE.

Bullish US tech and utilities sectors: strong earnings beats expected on AI demand

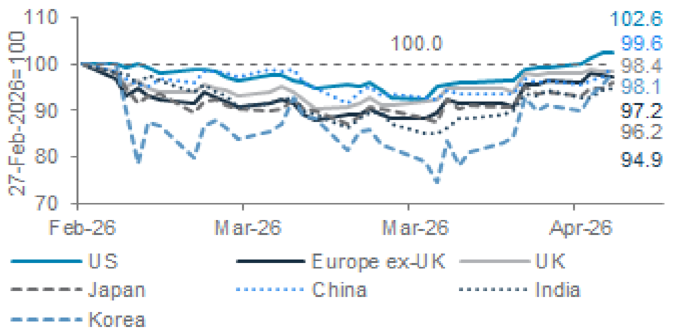
Prefer US short-duration High Yield bonds: attractive yield, low rate sensitivity

Bearish USD/CAD: elevated oil prices, broad USD weakness

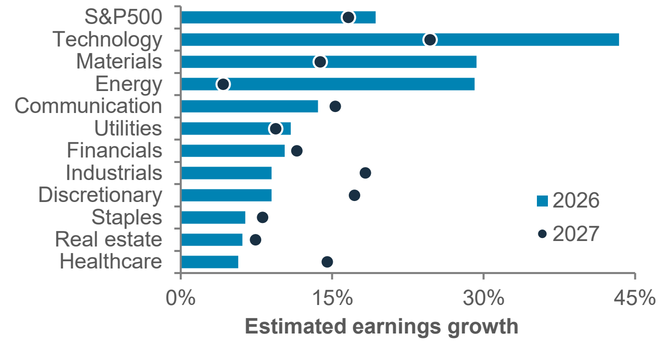
Charts of the week: Round trip

Equity markets have largely recovered their Middle East conflict losses; strong US earnings likely to sustain the recovery

Key equity markets since the start of the Middle East conflict*



Consensus estimates for US Q1 corporate earnings, by sectors



Source: Bloomberg, LSEG I/B/E/S, Standard Chartered; *Index: 100 = 27 February

Editorial

Full circle

Strategy summary: The global equities benchmark has recovered losses suffered during the Middle East conflict on hopes of a resolution. The recovery in risk assets once again highlights the importance of staying invested through geopolitical crises, as long as fundamentals don't change significantly. If the US-Iran truce holds, we expect strong US earnings to drive the next leg of the rally.

US Q1 bank earnings have beaten expectations, reflecting resilient macro fundamentals. We prefer the US technology and utilities equity sectors which are likely to report strong revenue and earnings on the back of soaring AI-related demand. We also expect the USD to continue its downtrend, after a brief period of consolidation, amid expectations of policy divergence between a neutral-to-dovish Fed and hawkish other major central banks such as the ECB, BoJ and BoE.

Staying invested delivers again as risk assets do a round trip: US equity markets have recovered all the losses suffered during the Middle East conflict and scaled record highs, with Europe and Asia not far behind, amid expectations of negotiations leading to an extended truce. Israel and Lebanon have also announced a ceasefire. Negotiations are likely to remain tense, sustaining near-term volatility. Nevertheless, as flagged at the start of the conflict, we continue to expect constraints on both parties to lead to a resolution and a restart of energy flows through the Hormuz strait in the next few weeks.

Constraints driving negotiations towards a truce: The constraints driving the conflicting parties to the negotiating table include: a) President's Trump need to revive his flagging approval ratings and sustain equity and bond markets heading into November's mid-term elections; b) the Iranian regime's need for self-preservation; and c) pressure from Iran's key trade partners in Asia for a swift resolution and restart of Middle East oil supplies since any delay in restart of supplies beyond April is likely to severely impact their economies. Also, sustaining US equity market strength has become an even bigger necessity for US administrations in the post-COVID years, given the so-called "wealth effect" of the upper income segment of the population increasingly driving services consumption and economic growth. Meanwhile, capping bond yields and gasoline prices is key to supporting a housing recovery and maintaining middle class real incomes.

Strong US earnings to drive next leg of equity rally. The US equities rebound is backed by robust corporate earnings. Major US banks have delivered strong Q1 earnings beats so far, driven by robust trading and mergers and acquisitions activity. This reflects a resilient macro backdrop. However, weaker guidance on net interest income is a headwind for banks more reliant on lending, rather than investment banking activity. Our technical and quantitative models remain risk-on and investor positioning in US equities is close to neutral, which leaves scope for further upside if earnings continue beat expectations.

We prefer the technology sector, especially the semiconductor segment, which is expected to report another quarter of strong revenue and earnings growth in the coming weeks. As the chart above shows, the tech sector continues to drive US earnings growth amid accelerating AI capex and surge in semiconductor prices. We also like the US utilities sector as it benefits from power demand from AI-related data centres.

USD faces further downside. The USD appears structurally weak. The USD index (DXY) has fallen for eight straight sessions after earlier failing to sustainably break above 100 at the peak of the Middle East conflict in March. Latest US data, including the Fed's Beige Book survey, point to negative impact on consumer/business sentiment, though real activity remains resilient. Upstream inflation pressures are starting to build due to higher oil prices. This is likely to keep the Fed, ECB and the BoJ monetary policies on hold in the next few months. Nevertheless, we see higher risk of the ECB and BoJ hiking rates by Q3 to counter inflation pressures. Meanwhile, the Fed, under a new Chair, is likely to ease by Q4 as its focus turns to supporting the job market. The widening rate differential is likely to drive the USD lower this year, supporting global risk assets.

— **Rajat Bhattacharya**

The weekly macro balance sheet

Our weekly net assessment: On balance, we see the past week's data and policy as positive for risk assets in the near-term

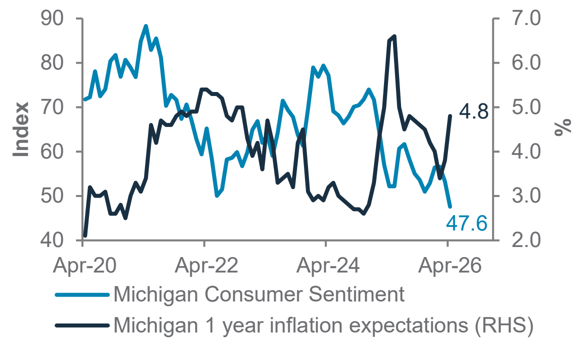
(+) factors: Stable US core inflation, strong China economic growth; likely easing of geopolitical tensions

(-) factors: Rising US inflation expectations; Fed rate cuts delayed

	Positive for risk assets	Negative for risk assets
Macro data	• US headline and core consumer prices rose less than expected by 3.3% y/y and 2.6% y/y respectively in March • US headline and core producer prices rose less than expected by 4.0% y/y and 3.8% y/y respectively in March • China GDP grew 5% y/y in Q1'26, beating estimates	• US Michigan consumer sentiment fell more than expected to 46.1 in April • US Michigan 1-year inflation expectations came in above expectations at 4.8% y/y in April • US NFIB Small Business Optimism Index came in below expectations at 95.8 • China exports grew less than expected by 2.5% y/y • China retail sales grew less than expected by 1.7% y/y in March
	Our assessment: Neutral – Stable US core inflation, strong China economic growth vs. rising US inflation expectations	
Policy developments	• ECB President Lagarde pushed back against growing market speculation of imminent rate hikes	• Fed's Goolsbee said rate cuts may need to wait until 2027 if high oil prices keep inflation elevated • Fed's Hammack expected interest rates to stay on hold for some time
	Our assessment: Neutral – Lower ECB rate hike expectations vs. Fed rate cuts delayed	
Other developments	• President Trump signalled a second round of US-Iran peace talks could start within the next two days, after the first round of talks over the weekend failed to secure an agreement • Lebanon and Israel engaged in first direct talks in decades to address the ongoing conflict	• Trump ordered a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz from Monday, targeting all ships entering or exiting Iranian ports • The US administration planned to use Section 301 to rebuild the tariff wall after the Supreme Court's tariffs ruling
	Our assessment: Positive – Likely easing of geopolitical tensions	

US consumer sentiment fell to a record-low, impacted by rising inflation concerns

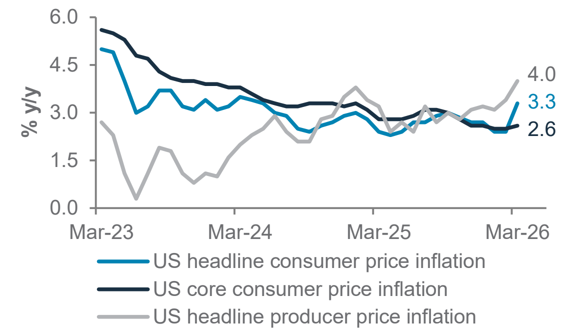
US Michigan consumer sentiment and Michigan 1-year inflation expectations



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

US headline consumer and producer inflation rose to the highest level since May 2024 and Feb 2023 respectively, but core consumer inflation was little changed

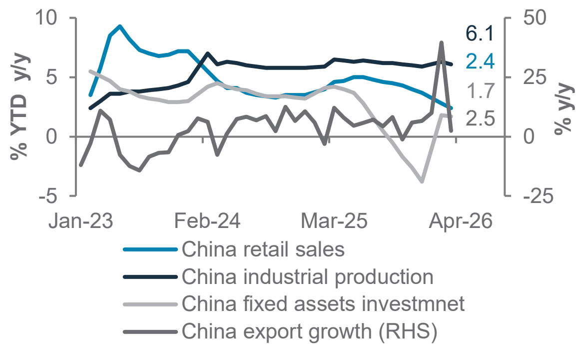
US headline and core consumer price inflation; US headline producer price inflation



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China's export growth slowed sharply in March, impacted by the Middle East conflict; retail sales and fixed asset investments missed estimates

China retail sales, industrial production, fixed asset investment and export growth



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions

What are the key takeaways from US banks' Q1 earnings? What is your view on the upcoming US tech earnings?

Our view: Uncertainty persists in US financials. We maintain a preference for semiconductors within global tech.

Rationale: Major US banks broadly delivered solid Q1 2026 earnings. **Resilient non-net interest income (NII) growth**, including strong investment banking momentum, was supported by favourable macro conditions underpinning M&A and equity trading activity. ROE also remained strong (mid-to-high-teens) across major banks. In contrast, weaker NII guidance warrants caution, especially when it comes to banks with higher sensitivity of NII to top-line growth, given our expectations for further Fed rate cuts in H2 2026.

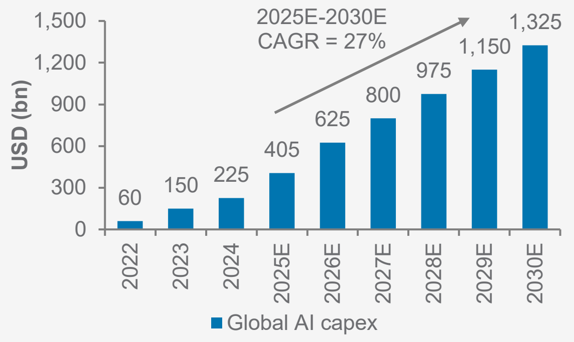
Middle East conflict uncertainty remains a risk to the US economy and Fed interest-rate trajectory. As more regional banks report, the focus will remain on rate and capital adequacy outlook, private credit and provisioning trend exposure, deposit competition, credit quality and issuance activity, and AI-related disruption vs. opportunity.

Focus now turns to global tech earnings in coming weeks. Recent semiconductor earnings support our **preference for semis** within global tech, driven by accelerating global AI capex. With recent valuation de-rating, the sector offers an attractive entry point.

— **Michelle Kam, CFA**, *Investment Strategist*

AI's capital intensity is expected to stay elevated

Global AI capex and estimates over the years



Source: Company reports, Standard Chartered

What are the investment implications of technology companies' surging power demand?

Our view: We are positive on the US utilities sector, given the increasing demand for power. Companies involved in power grid upgrades and maintenance are also expected to benefit.

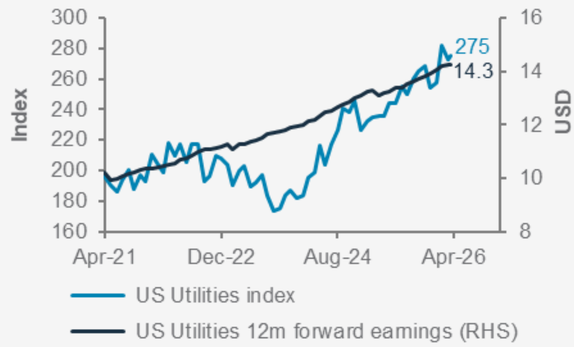
Rationale: Growing electricity demand from tech companies to power their AI-linked data centres has highlighted the advantage of new technologies that can deliver power years faster than established power generation sources. **'Time to power'** (speed of electricity delivery) has become an important consideration besides cost and supply chain concerns. Renewables are an alternative, but their intermittent nature means they are used to supplement baseload power sources.

As investors explore opportunities in new power technologies, we believe that **sizing is critical**. Remain cautious and align allocations to unproven technologies considering your risk appetite. We expect US utilities, including independent power producers and nuclear operators, to benefit from the structural power demand growth. We also expect major investment in the US electricity network, driven by ageing infrastructure, digitalisation, energy transition needs, etc.

— **Fook Hien Yap**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

The US utilities equity sector is attractive, with steady earnings growth and a boost from technology companies' power demand

MSCI US Utilities sector and its 12-month forward EPS



Source: FactSet, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Are you still positive on Developed Market (DM) HY corporate bonds after recent yield premium tightening?

Our view: Given market volatility could persist, we prefer short-duration US HY bonds to capture still-attractive yield.

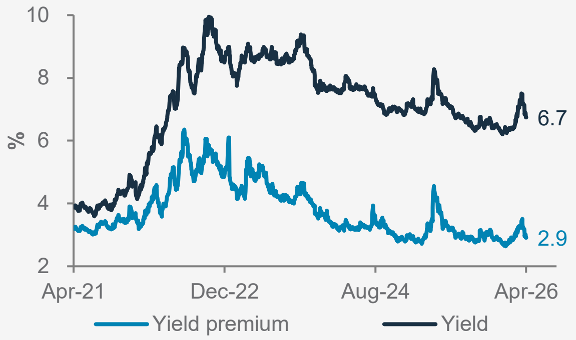
Rationale: Middle East conflict escalation initially caused the DM HY yield premium to widen from the tights, but it has since **retraced much of the widening after US-Iran peace talks began in early April**. We believe a quick conflict resolution is unlikely, but our base case assumes there will be no material impact on global growth and inflation. Meanwhile, credit fundamentals remain solid, with below-average default rates and refinancing risks largely deferred until 2027-28 following earlier refinancing activities. Fund flows turned positive again in April as peace talks began.

While the absolute DM HY yield remains attractive, we expect additional performance from yield premium tightening to be more marginal. Thus, a prudent way to play the DM HY theme is through our opportunistic idea, **short-duration US HY corporate bonds**. This offers the advantage of lower drawdowns amid volatility while capturing the still-attractive yield on HY corporate bonds.

— **Ray Heung**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

Global HY bonds' yield premium is almost back to the lows, but absolute yield is still attractive

Bloomberg Global HY Corporate Bond Index yield and yield premium



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

What is your outlook for oil prices and USD/CAD as US and Iran negotiate a truce?

Our view: Crude oil prices are expected to remain elevated. USD/CAD expected to continue drifting lower, driven primarily by a soft USD; support seen at 1.3540.

Rationale: The Iran crisis has injected a significant geopolitical risk premium into global oil prices. WTI prices have eased from a peak near USD 112/bbl to above USD 90/bbl today. The pullback reflects signs of near-term demand softening and conflict de-escalation. However, continued oil transit route disruptions and the drawdown of floating storage buffers could quickly drive prices higher again. Hence, the balance of risks to our USD 75/bbl three-month oil price outlook is increasingly skewed to the upside.

This is supportive of the Canadian dollar (CAD), given its correlation with oil. However, the dominance of USD weakness means the CAD has remained resilient despite the recent pullback in oil prices.. As a result, USD/CAD has trended lower.

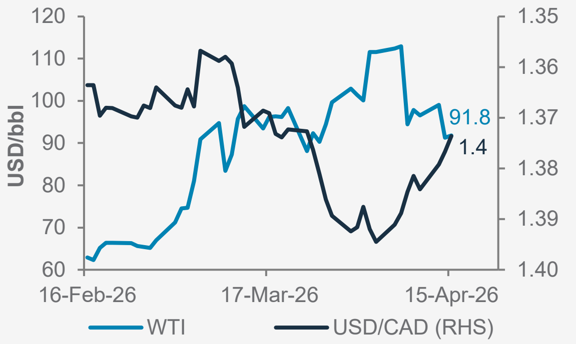
Technically, the bearish USD/CAD trend is reinforced by a break below the 200-day moving average and the 38.2% retracement level of March's rally. Near term, the pair remains biased lower, contingent on continued USD softness and sustained geopolitical risks.

— **Anthony Naab, CFA,** *Investment Strategist*

— **Iris Yuen,** *Investment Strategist*

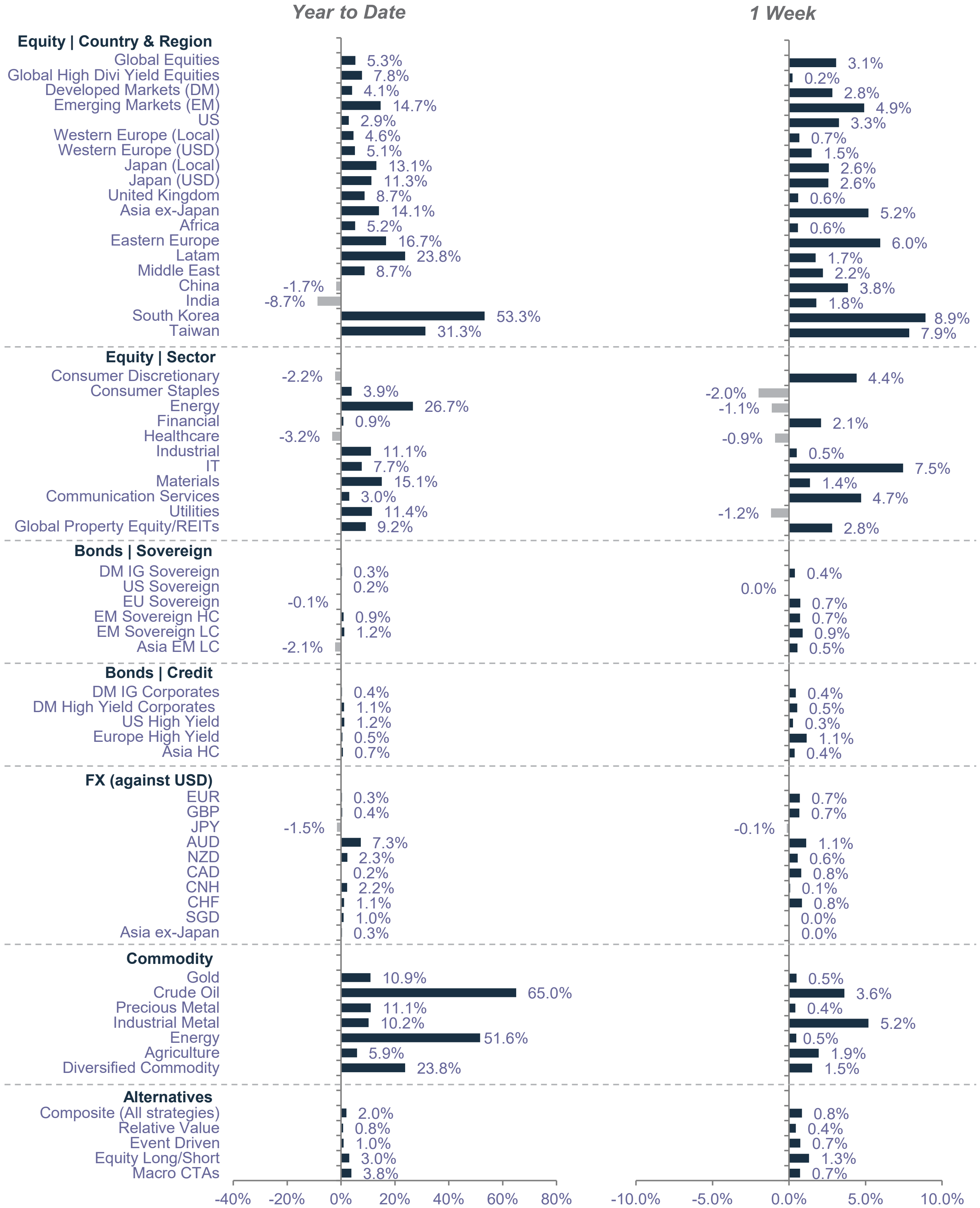
While USD/CAD typically tracks oil, its recent decline despite softer WTI signals a breakdown in the correlation, driven mainly by USD weakness

WTI spot prices and USD/CAD



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Market performance summary*



Sources: MSCI, JP Morgan, Barclays Capital, Citigroup, Dow Jones, HFRX, FTSE, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

*Performance in USD terms unless otherwise stated, 2026 YTD performance from 31 December 2025 to 16 April 2026; 1-week period: 9 April 2026 to 16 April 2026

Our 12-month asset class views at a glance

Asset class			
Equities	▲	**Preferred Sectors**	
US	▲	US Technology	▲
Europe ex-UK	▼	US Healthcare	▲
UK	▼	US Utilities	▲
Asia ex-Japan	▲	Europe ex-UK Financials	▲
Japan	◆		
Other EM	◆	China Communication	▲
		China Technology	▲
Bonds	▼	China Healthcare	▲
Credit			
Asia USD	◆	**Alternatives**	◆
Corp DM HY	▲		
Govt EM USD	▲	**Gold**	▲
Corp DM IG	◆		
Govt			
Govt EM Local	▲		
Govt DM IG	▼		

Source: Standard Chartered Global Investment Committee

Legend: ▲ Most preferred | ▼ Less preferred | ◆ Core holding

Economic and market calendar

	Market	Event	Period	Expected	Prior
MON					
TUE	EUR	ZEW Survey Expectations	Apr	–	-0.5
	EUR	ZEW Survey Current Situation	Apr	–	-62.9
	USD	Retail Sales Ex Auto and Gas	Mar	0.2%	0.4%
WED	GBP	CPI y/y	Mar	–	3.0%
	GBP	CPI Core y/y	Mar	–	3.2%
	EUR	Consumer Confidence	Apr P	–	-16.3
THU	EUR	S&P Global Eurozone Manufacturing PMI	Apr P	–	51.6
	EUR	S&P Global Eurozone Services PMI	Apr P	–	50.2
	USD	Chicago Fed Nat Activity Index	Mar	–	-0.11
	USD	Initial Jobless Claims	18-Apr	–	–
	USD	Continuing Claims	11-Apr	–	–
	USD	S&P Global US Manufacturing PMI	Apr P	–	52.3
	USD	S&P Global US Services PMI	Apr P	–	49.8
	USD	S&P Global US Composite PMI	Apr P	–	50.3
FRI/SAT	EUR	IFO Business Climate	Apr	–	86.4

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Prior data are for the preceding period unless otherwise indicated. Data are % change on previous period unless otherwise indicated
P - preliminary data, F - final data, sa - seasonally adjusted, y/y - year-on-year, m/m - month-on-month

The S&P500 has next interim resistance at 7,289

Technical indicators for key markets as of 16 Apr close

Index	Spot	1st support	1st resistance	12m forward P/E (x)	12m forward dividend yield (%)
S&P 500	7,041	6,555	7,289	20.7	1.2
STOXX 50	5,933	5,545	6,154	15.4	3.1
FTSE 100	10,590	9,944	10,962	13.3	3.4
TOPIX	3,814	3,567	3,943	17.3	2.3
Shanghai Comp	4,056	3,864	4,178	13.6	2.9
Hang Seng	26,394	24,931	27,130	11.4	3.3
Nifty 50	24,197	22,786	25,004	18.4	1.6
MSCI Asia ex-Japan	1,039	945	1,086	12.5	2.1
MSCI EM	1,603	1,459	1,676	11.9	2.6
Crude oil (WTI)	94.7	80.2	113.4	na	na
Gold	4,790	4,245	5,190	na	na
UST 10Y Yield	4.31	4.16	4.47	na	na

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Note: These short-term technical levels are based on models and may differ from a more qualitative analysis provided in other pages

Investor diversity has normalised across asset classes

Our proprietary market diversity indicators as of 16 Apr close

Level 1	Diversity	1-month trend	Fractal dimension
Global Bonds	●	↑	2.16
Global Equities	●	→	1.71
Gold	●	↑	1.82
Equity			
MSCI US	●	→	1.88
MSCI Europe	●	↑	1.80
MSCI AC AXJ	●	↑	1.58
Fixed Income			
DM Corp Bond	●	↑	3.00
DM High Yield	●	↑	1.76
EM USD	●	↑	1.78
EM Local	●	↑	1.80
Asia USD	●	↑	1.87
Currencies			
EUR/USD	●	↓	1.61

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; **Fractal dimensions below 1.25 indicate extremely low market diversity/high risk of a reversal**

Legend: ● High | ◐ Low to mid | ○ Critically low

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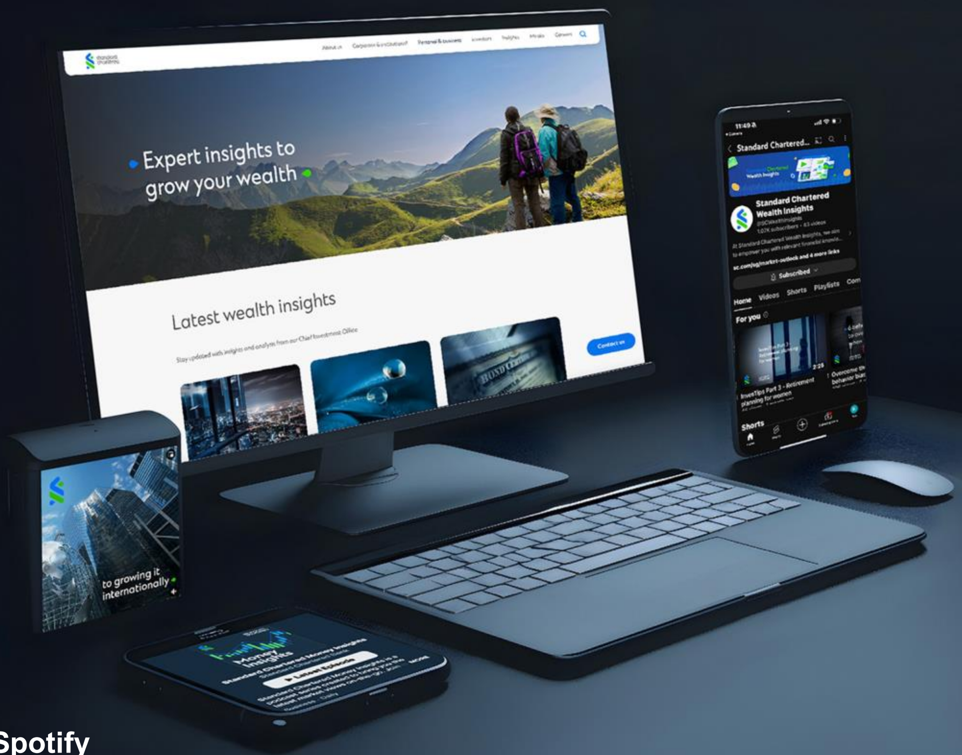

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WS Global CIO Office
10 April 2026

Weekly Market View

Navigating the Ceasefire

→ The US-Iran ceasefire largely aligns with our base case of a 4-6 week conflict, helping limit the growth and inflation damage from high energy prices.

→ However, this does not eliminate downside risk scenarios entirely. Negotiations need to lead to a lasting agreement to avoid risking a renewed round of hostilities and high energy prices. Bringing oil output back to pre-conflict levels is also expected to take time given logistical challenges.

→ For now, we continue to favour well-diversified portfolios alongside downside risk hedges such as inflation-protected bonds. Gold is expected to rally as central bank selling eases.

→ In the short-term, we expect the US technology sector to benefit from market positioning, improving fundamentals and cheaper valuations. Asian equities, as well as Developed Market high yield and Emerging Market bonds, are likely to benefit from lower oil prices.

5-7 years remains the sweet spot for bond portfolio maturity profiles

Bullish NZD following hawkish central bank comments

Expect Gold to rebound above USD 5000 as short-term pressures ease

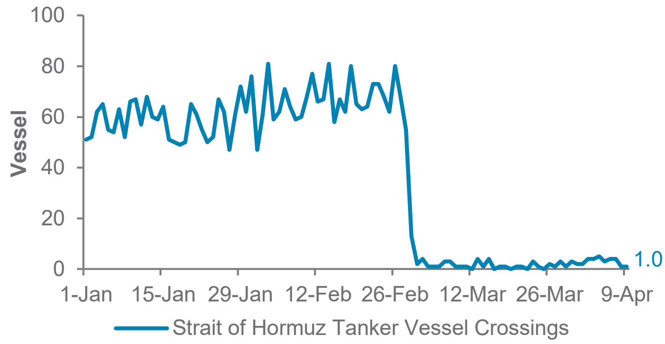
Important disclosures can be found in the Disclosures Appendix.

Charts of the week: Earnings robust but monitor energy risks

Robust earnings to continue supporting equities; Tankers crossing Hormuz Strait a key metric of energy supply recovery

S&P500 earnings growth; E=expected

Strait of Hormuz tanker crossings (latest: 9-Apr)



Source: LSEG I/B/E/S, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Editorial

Navigating the Ceasefire

Strategy summary: The US-Iran ceasefire largely aligns with our base case of a 4-6-week conflict, helping limit the growth and inflation damage from high energy prices. However, this does not eliminate downside scenario risks. Negotiations need to lead to a lasting agreement to avoid risking a renewed round of hostilities and high energy prices. Bringing oil output back to pre-conflict levels is also expected to take time given logistical challenges. This means oil prices are unlikely to fall back to pre-conflict levels very quickly. For now, we continue to favour well-diversified portfolios alongside downside risk hedges such as inflation-protected bonds. In the short-term, we expect the US technology sector to benefit from market positioning, improving fundamentals and cheaper valuations. Asian equities, as well as Developed Market high yield and Emerging Market bonds, are likely to benefit from lower oil prices.

Ceasefire consistent with our base case scenario: The US-Iran agreement for a two-week ceasefire in the sixth week of the Middle East conflict aligns with our longstanding base case scenario of a 4-6 week conflict that we laid out after the outbreak of hostilities. Assuming the ceasefire results in a lasting agreement, this should help limit the damage from high oil prices on global growth and inflation.

Not out of the woods yet. Near term optimism aside, the ceasefire does not eliminate the downside risk scenario. We continue to monitor two risks. First is the negotiation process itself, which needs to progress positively towards a long-lasting agreement. A failure to do so would risk a resumption of hostilities and a new surge in energy prices. The negotiation process itself is unlikely to be smooth, which could result in some two-way volatility over the course of the two-week ceasefire even if the trend in risky assets is a positive one.

Complete reversal of oil price rise unlikely. A second risk is oil prices remaining elevated for an extended period given the time required to restart production, return shipping to full capacity and repair damaged energy infrastructure.

Macro and policy developments remain positive for risk assets: Looking beyond the Middle East conflict alone, US job market data last week showed an improvement in both job creation and the unemployment rate. On-hold policy decisions by India's RBI and New Zealand's RBNZ were consistent with earlier on-hold decisions by the Fed and ECB. The RBNZ's hawkish tone means we now see room for the NZD to strengthen, particularly against our weak-USD view. While comments across all major central banks displayed concern about possible risks arising from high oil prices, a willingness to balance inflationary risks with supporting growth provides a relatively supportive backdrop. We continue to expect the Fed to leave rates unchanged in H1 and resume rate cuts in H2.

Prefer Emerging Market, High Yield bonds. The policy outlook supports the case for locking in bond yields on any rebounds. Within a diversified portfolio, we continue to favour Emerging Market and Developed Market high yield bonds.

Near-term outlook positive for equities. Day-to-day volatility notwithstanding, we believe the ceasefire pause improves the near-term outlook for risky assets. The US earnings growth outlook for Q1 is strong and several investor surveys and positioning data suggest US retail investors are at, or close to, bearish capitulation. In our view, this leaves room for US equities to be very sensitive to positive, or less-negative, news.

We like US technology sector, Asian equities. Near-term, we expect the US technology sector and Asian equities to lead a rebound in equities on the back of lower oil prices. We had previously pointed out that the US tech sector's valuation premium over the S&P500 had fallen back to 2019 lows. This comes against reports of strong AI-sub-sector earnings, reports of improved GPU pricing and easing funding concerns in recent days. This supports our positive sector view and preference for the semiconductor sub-sector. Regionally, Asian equities remain amongst the most sensitive to energy prices, which suggests they lead any rebound driven by falling oil prices. We favour Taiwan, India and China equities within the region.

— **Manpreet Gill**

The weekly macro balance sheet

Our weekly net assessment: On balance, we see the past week's data and policy as neutral for risk assets in the near-term

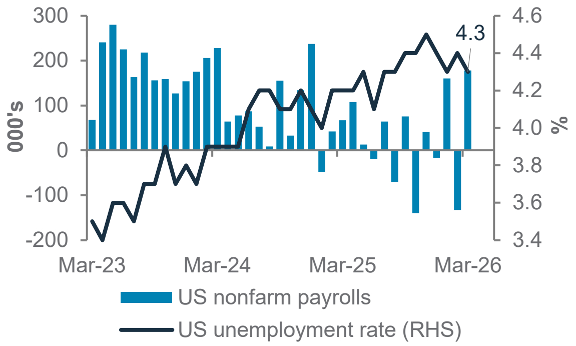
(+) factors: Robust US job market; likely easing of conflict

(-) factors: Weak US services data; potential Fed rate hike; escalating sector- and country-specific tariffs

	Positive for risk assets	Negative for risk assets
Macro data	• US non-farm payrolls rose more than expected by 178,000 in March; while February's payrolls were revised lower • US unemployment rate fell unexpectedly to 4.3% • Euro area retail sales growth came in slightly above at 1.7% y/y in Feb	• US ISM services PMI fell unexpectedly to 54 in Mar, with falling employment and rising prices paid • US durable goods orders fell by 1.4% y/y in February • Euro Sentix investor confidence fell more than expected to -19.2 in April • China consumer price inflation missed estimates, while producer price inflation rose in March
	Our assessment: Neutral – Robust US job market vs. weak US services data	
Policy developments		• March Fed meeting minutes showed growing openness to rate hikes and revealed heightened concern over inflation • RBI and RBNZ kept rate unchanged as expected, but warned of growth and inflation risk from US-Iran conflict
	Our assessment: Negative – Potential Fed rate hike; central banks rate pause	
Other developments	• The US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire after President Trump's threat of massive attacks, as Iran said it will reopen Hormuz Strait • US and Iran are set to hold peace talks in Pakistan this weekend	• Israel launched a large wave of air strikes across Lebanon, casting doubt over the ceasefire • Trump threatened a new 50% tariff on any country supplying weapons to Iran • Trump has authorised tariffs of up to 100% on certain imported drugs
	Our assessment: Positive – Likely easing of Middle East conflict vs. escalating sector- and country-specific tariffs	

US non-farm payrolls rose 178,000 in March, reporting the largest gain for any month since 2024, and a reversal from a decline in February

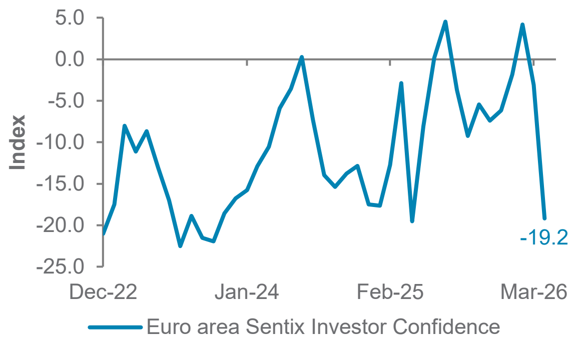
US non-farm payrolls and unemployment rate



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Euro area Sentix investor confidence fell to softest reading since April 2025 as investor sentiment plunges amid the US-Iran conflict

Euro area Sentix investor confidence



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China consumer price inflation rose less than expected in March, while producer price inflation rose by 0.5% y/y, marking the first increase in over 41 months and ending a long deflationary streak

China consumer and producer price inflation

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions

What do you expect from the upcoming US earnings season?

Our view: We expect resilient earnings growth to provide fundamental support to US equities to move higher in 2026.

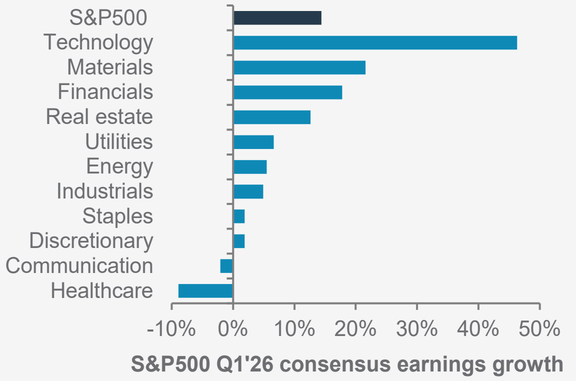
Rationale: Amid geopolitical volatility, the earnings season is a good time to revisit the fundamental health of US corporates. The **consensus estimate is for 14.4% earnings growth in Q1 2026** for the S&P500, led by the technology, materials and financials sectors. Healthcare, communication services and consumer discretionary remain laggards. Given the oil price spike, investors will monitor guidance on cost inflation as well as supply chain disruptions.

The consensus estimate for full-year 2026 earnings growth so far remains resilient at 19.0%, revised up from an initial 15.6% estimated at the start of the year. Growth in 2027 is also projected to be healthy at 16.6%. US strength continues to be broad-based, with **positive growth forecasts across all sectors** in 2026 and 2027. Technology leads with a projected growth of +43.3% in 2026 and +24.4% in 2027, driven by strong AI capital expenditure (capex) growth. We expect sustained AI investment to be a significant underpinning for overall US earnings growth over the next year.

— **Fook Hien Yap**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

S&P500 earnings are expected to grow by 14.4% in Q1 2026, led by the technology, materials and financials sectors

Consensus Q1 2026 earnings growth by sectors in the S&P500 Index



Source: LSEG I/B/E/S, Standard Chartered

How do recent tech sector developments impact your view on the sector?

Our view: AI developments support our bullish view on the technology sector. In particular, we see global semiconductors as an attractive opportunistic idea.

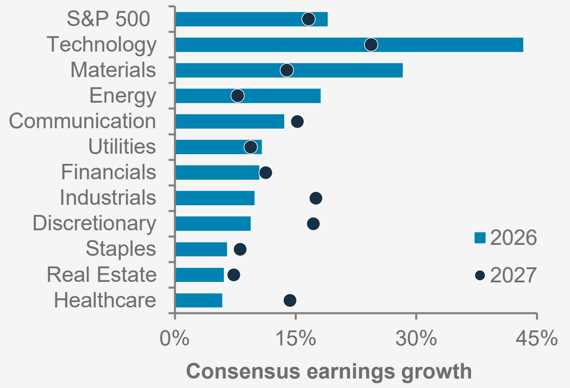
Rationale: The technology sector continues to see progress in AI developments. The **monetisation of AI models is accelerating**, evidenced by recent record revenue announced by an AI major. In addition, new models continue to be unveiled with rapid performance improvement. Further, industry data points to a **sharp spike in hourly graphics processing unit (GPU) pricing** across major platforms. GPUs power AI computations. Pricing for even four-year-old GPUs has risen nearly 40% recently, according to SemiAnalysis. This reflects strong demand from AI agents, which generate a high volume of computation requests.

Third, funding concerns around OpenAI have eased after its record USD 122bn funding round. As a central torchbearer of the global AI ecosystem, this capital infusion eases concerns about the company's ability to fund essential AI capex.

— **Fook Hien Yap**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

US earnings are expected to grow strongly in 2026 and 2027, led by the technology sector

Consensus 2026 and 2027 earnings growth by sectors in the S&P500 Index



Source: LSEG I/B/E/S, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

How might US plans to impose 100% tariffs on imported patented drugs impact the global pharmaceutical industry?

Our view: We expect the recent US tariffs on imported drugs to have limited impact on the global pharmaceutical industry. We remain Overweight on the US healthcare sector.

Rationale: The White House recently announced 100% tariffs on patented medicines, effective 31 July for large enterprises and 29 September for smaller entities. These are designed to incentivise domestic manufacturing relocation and most-favoured-nation (MFN) drug pricing concessions.

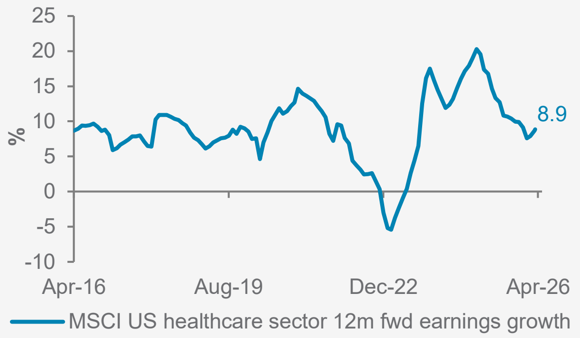
That said, tariff exposure varies materially by geography. Regions with concluded trade agreements, including the EU and Japan, are capped at 15%, while the UK enjoys even more favourable terms. China faces the full 100% tariff without exemptions, whereas India's generic drug sector currently remains protected until a 2027 review.

While US pharma companies face twin pressures of higher costs and tighter pricing, most major firms have already reached favourable agreements with the administration, significantly reducing their tariff burden. We remain positive on the US healthcare sector, as its defensive characteristics and stable earnings growth provide meaningful portfolio resilience amid broader macro volatility.

— **Jason Wong**, *Senior Equity Analyst*

US healthcare sector's defensive characteristics and stable earnings growth provide meaningful portfolio resilience amid broader macro volatility

MSCI US Healthcare sector 12-month forward earnings growth



Source: FactSet, Standard Chartered

How does the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) decision to keep its key policy rate unchanged at 5.25% and the ongoing Middle East conflict affect your outlook for Indian equities?

Our view: Indian equities offer attractive risk-reward, backed by strong growth and earnings expectations.

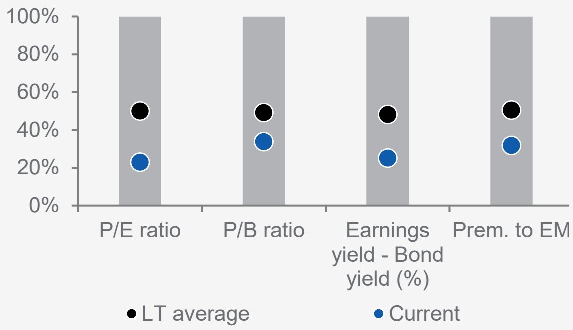
Rationale: The RBI remains optimistic on FY27 GDP growth (6.9%), while its inflation forecast of 4.6% remains within its tolerance band of 2-6%. RBI Governor Malhotra noted that despite downside risks, India's strong fundamentals provide resilience to withstand shocks. Guidance on maintaining sufficient liquidity indicates focus on supporting growth, with the inflation spike being viewed as transitory.

We believe Indian equities remain attractive despite headwinds, as Q4 earnings hold up. We expect robust economic growth in 2026, supported by the US-India trade deal and a growth-focused Union Budget. This could cushion the moderate, temporary impact of oil price shocks. Further, equity valuations have turned attractive, both in absolute terms (trading below long-term historical averages) and relative to major peers and bonds post the sharp correction in March. With foreign investor positioning very light, we see foreign investors rotating back into Indian equities on conflict de-escalation.

— **Michelle Castelino**, *Investment Strategist*

Indian equities' absolute and relative valuations are attractive

Percentile of key valuation parameters vs. their respective 10-year averages for Indian equities



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

What underpins your preference for intermediate-term (5-7-year) bonds? What could prompt a reassessment?

Our view: Intermediate-term bonds offer a fine balance of risk-reward at this juncture. We would shorten the duration if geopolitical risks escalate or the Fed pivots hawkishly, while a declining term premium would argue for selective extension.

Rationale: Recent market developments continue to reinforce the case for intermediate-term bonds from a risk-reward perspective. Since the Middle East conflict began in March, the **US government bond yield curve has flattened** as concerns over a near-term inflation spike have tempered rate cut expectations and pushed short-dated yields higher. This has left yield curve measures, such as the 10-2-year spread, near levels last seen in 2025.

We see scope for the curve to re-steepen over the next 6-12 months, driven primarily by declining front-end yields as policy-easing expectations re-emerge. Sitting near the yield curve's inflection point, the **5-7-year segment offers an attractive balance between interest rate risk and returns**. It captures most of the incremental yield of longer-dated bonds while avoiding their disproportionate volatility and sensitivity to inflation surprises and fiscal uncertainty. From a portfolio construction perspective, this positioning supports a resilient, flexible fixed-income allocation. We would shorten duration if geopolitical risks re-intensify or the Fed turns hawkish, while a renewed flattening driven by a declining term premium would argue for selectively extending duration.

— **Cedric Lam**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

US Treasury 2-10-year yield spread has returned to levels last seen in 2025

Yield differentials between the US 2- and 10-year US government bond yield

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

The Reserve Bank of New Zealand (RBNZ) left rates unchanged at 2.25%. What is your latest NZD/USD outlook?

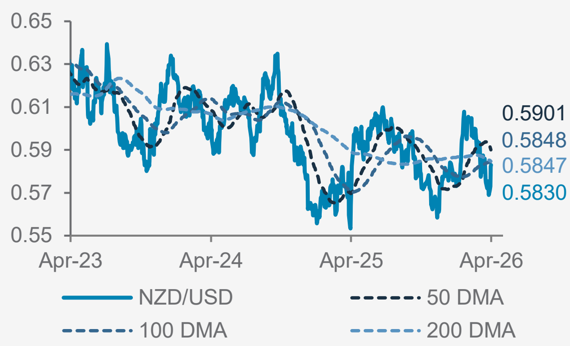
Our view: We see upside potential for NZD/USD following the RBNZ's hawkish hold, with the pair likely to test resistance around 0.60.

Rationale: RBNZ Governor Breman noted the central bank will **raise interest rates if core inflation accelerates**. The RBNZ remains concerned that medium-term inflation pressures could overshoot and said it will act decisively with rate hikes if inflation picks up. Despite projecting somewhat softer near-term growth, Breman still expects the New Zealand economy to expand this year. Technically, NZD/USD has bullishly breached the resistance of its descending trendline formed in early February. We expect further upside, with a three-month forecast of 0.60.

— **Iris Yuen**, *Investment Strategist*

NZD/USD rebounded and surpassed its 200DMA; we expect bullish momentum in the near term

NZD/USD and technicals



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

Why has gold failed to rally despite the Middle East conflict and inflation? Is your long-term bullish view still intact?

Our view: Gold's safe-haven appeal has been tempered by market volatility and rising interest rates, but we remain bullish long-term. We expect a recovery as geopolitical tensions subside and energy markets stabilise.

Rationale: Since the Middle East conflict began, **gold prices have moved in tandem with equities**. Markets have been selling gold to cover losses in other assets, diminishing gold's safe-haven appeal. Meanwhile, central bank activity has been mixed; in February, net purchases totalled 27 tonnes, largely due to Poland acquiring 20 tonnes. Turkey and Russia were notable net sellers, offloading 8 tonnes and 6 tonnes respectively.

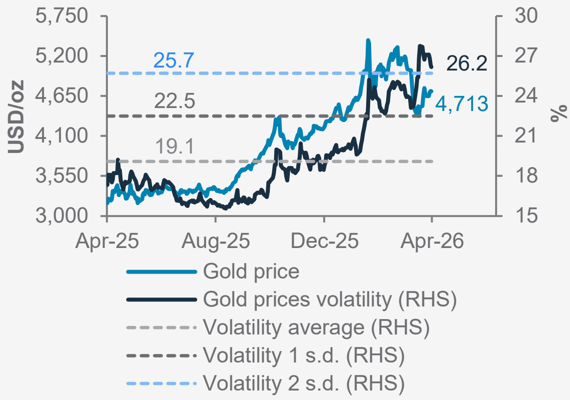
Investors remain highly sensitive to developments around the USD and shifts in interest rate expectations. The conflict has added to inflation pressures via higher oil prices, prompting central banks to consider rate hikes or maintain elevated rates. Higher interest rates reduce the appeal of non-yielding assets such as gold, prompting some investors to shift away from the metal.

However, **our long-term outlook remains positive**. Should geopolitical tensions ease, particularly with a lasting ceasefire and stable energy flows via the Strait of Hormuz, gold's rally is likely to resume. We see gold prices at USD 5,375/oz in three months.

— **Iris Yuen**, *Investment Strategist*

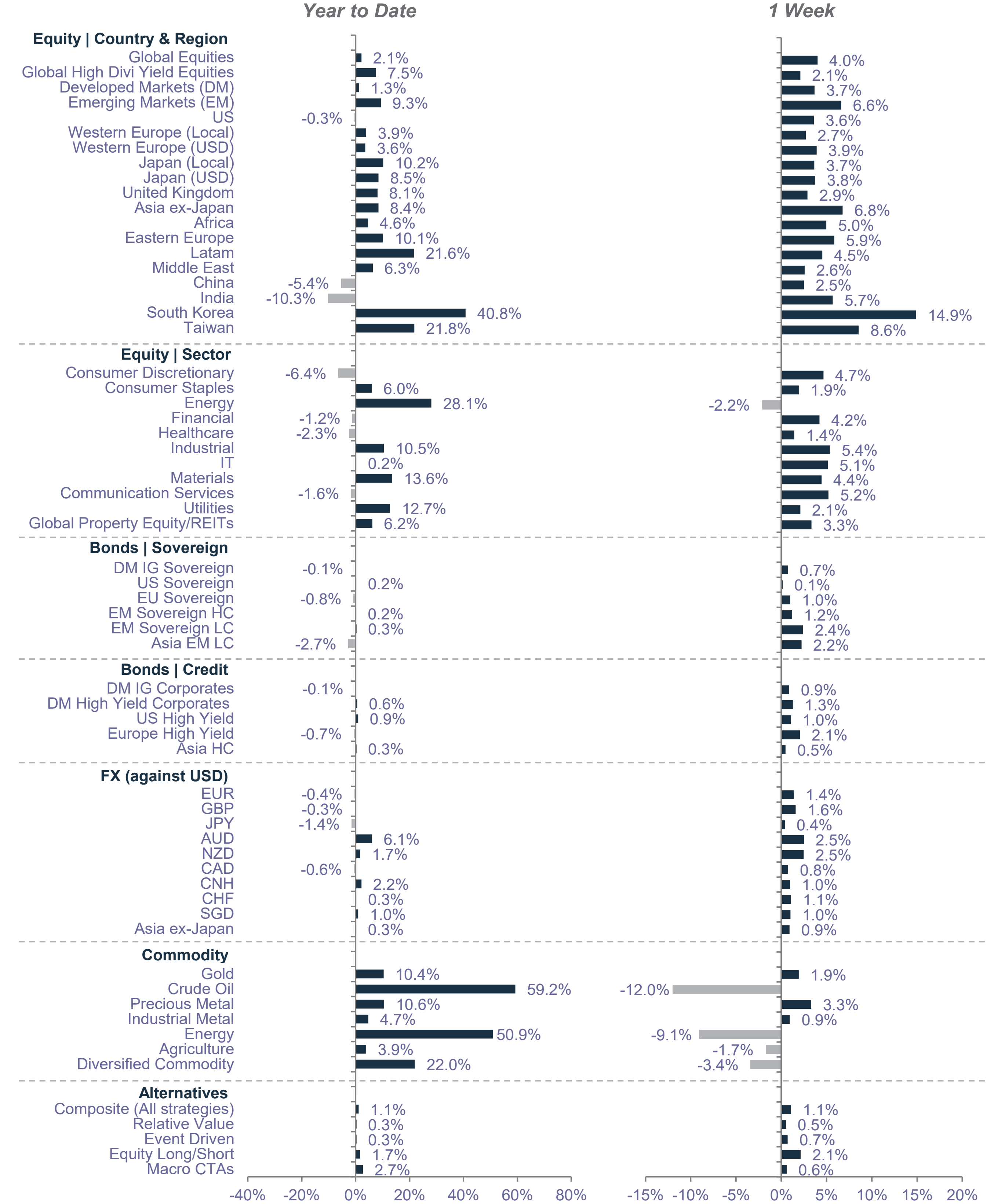
Gold volatility has surged significantly since the Middle East conflict began in February

Gold prices and volatility



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Market performance summary*



Sources: MSCI, JP Morgan, Barclays Capital, Citigroup, Dow Jones, HFRX, FTSE, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

*Performance in USD terms unless otherwise stated, 2026 YTD performance from 31 December 2025 to 9 April 2026; 1-week period: 2 April 2026 to 9 April 2026

Our 12-month asset class views at a glance

Asset class		Preferred Sectors	
Equities	▲		
US	▲	US Technology	▲
Europe ex-UK	▼	US Healthcare	▲
UK	▼	US Utilities	▲
Asia ex-Japan	▲	Europe ex-UK Financials	▲
Japan	◆		
Other EM	◆	China Communication	▲
		China Technology	▲
Bonds	▼	China Healthcare	▲
Credit			
Asia USD	◆	**Alternatives**	◆
Corp DM HY	▲		
Govt EM USD	▲	**Gold**	▲
Corp DM IG	◆		
Govt			
Govt EM Local	▲		
Govt DM IG	▼		

Source: Standard Chartered Global Investment Committee

Legend: ▲ Most preferred | ▼ Less preferred | ◆ Core holding

Economic and market calendar

	Market	Event	Period	Expected	Prior
MON	USD	Existing Home Sales	Mar	–	4.09m
TUE	USD	NFIB Small Business Optimism	Mar	–	98.8
	USD	PPI Final Demand y/y	Mar	–	3.4%
	USD	PPI Ex Food and Energy y/y	Mar	–	3.9%
	CNH	Trade Balance	Mar	$109.05b	$90.98b
	CNH	Exports y/y	Mar	10.9%	39.6%
	CNH	Imports y/y	Mar	14.4%	13.8%
WED	USD	Empire Manufacturing	Apr	–	-0.2
	USD	Import Price Index y/y	Mar	–	1.3%
	USD	Leading Index	Feb	–	-0.1%
THU	CNH	GDP y/y	1Q	4.8%	4.5%
	CNH	Retail Sales y/y	Mar	2.4%	–
	CNH	Industrial Production y/y	Mar	5.3%	–
	CNH	Property Investment YTD y/y	Mar	-11.5%	-11.1%
	USD	Philadelphia Fed Business Outlook	Apr	–	18.1
FRI/SAT					

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Prior data are for the preceding period unless otherwise indicated. Data are % change on previous period unless otherwise indicated
P - preliminary data, F - final data, sa - seasonally adjusted, y/y - year-on-year, m/m - month-on-month

The S&P500 has next interim resistance at 7,008

Technical indicators for key markets as of 9 Apr close

Index	Spot	1st support	1st resistance	12m forward P/E (x)	12m forward dividend yield (%)
S&P 500	6,825	6,479	7,008	20.2	1.3
STOXX 50	5,896	5,536	6,098	15.4	3.1
FTSE 100	10,603	9,953	10,971	13.4	3.4
TOPIX	3,741	3,530	3,870	17.1	2.3
Shanghai Comp	3,966	3,793	4,140	13.3	3.0
Hang Seng	25,752	24,554	26,601	11.1	3.3
Nifty 50	23,775	22,537	24,658	18.2	1.7
MSCI Asia ex-Japan	987	925	1,023	12.7	2.2
MSCI EM	1,529	1,431	1,584	12.1	2.7
Crude oil (WTI)	97.9	77.2	118.1	na	na
Gold	4,767	4,164	5,304	na	na
UST 10Y Yield	4.28	4.08	4.48	na	na

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Note: These short-term technical levels are based on models and may differ from a more qualitative analysis provided in other pages

Investor diversity has normalised across asset classes

Our proprietary market diversity indicators as of 9 Apr close

Level 1	Diversity	1-month trend	Fractal dimension
Global Bonds	●	↑	1.95
Global Equities	●	↑	2.20
Gold	●	↑	1.70
Equity			
MSCI US	●	→	1.79
MSCI Europe	●	↑	1.77
MSCI AC AXJ	●	↑	1.72
Fixed Income			
DM Corp Bond	●	↑	2.08
DM High Yield	●	↑	1.91
EM USD	●	↑	1.94
EM Local	●	↑	2.21
Asia USD	●	↑	2.07
Currencies			
EUR/USD	●	↑	1.95

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; **Fractal dimensions below 1.25 indicate extremely low market diversity/high risk of a reversal**

Legend: ● High | ◐ Low to mid | ○ Critically low

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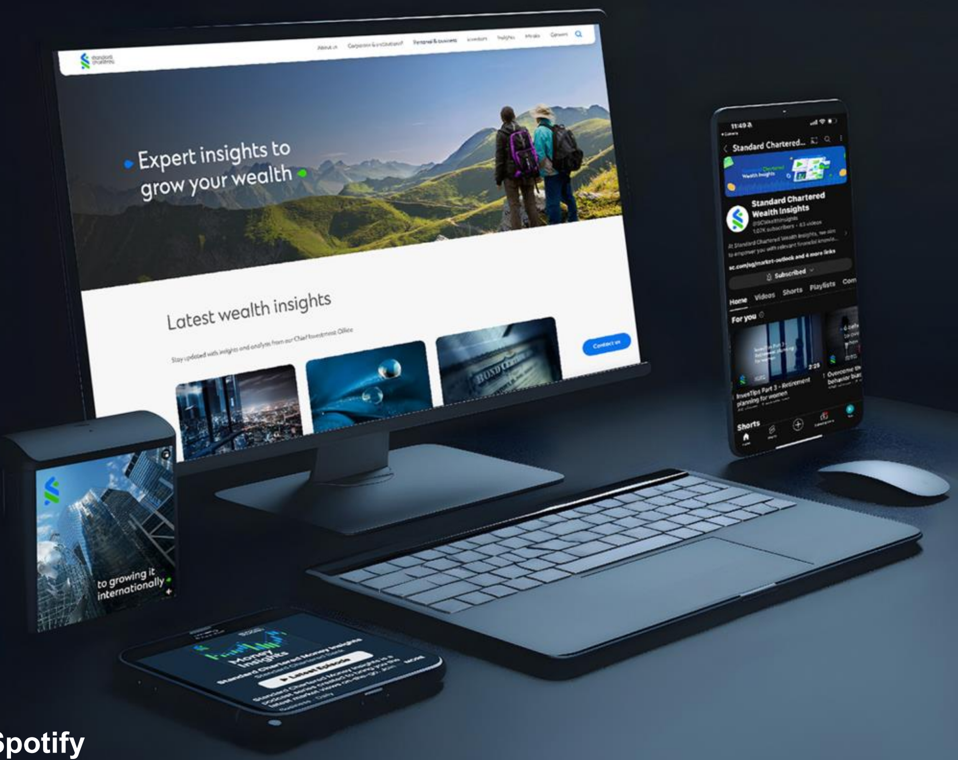

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WS Global CIO Office
2 April 2026

Weekly Market View

Inching towards a stalemate

→ US President Trump's plan to end military operations in the Middle East within 2-3 weeks has eased fears of a drawn-out conflict. However, uncertainty remains about a near-term escalation in the conflict and when normal shipping through the Hormuz Strait will resume.

→ Trump stated the responsibility for reopening the strait now falls to Asian and European governments, whose economies depend heavily on Gulf energy supplies. This signals tough negotiations ahead.

→ In this environment, we prefer investments in quality stocks with robust profit margins and earnings moats, especially within technology and utilities sectors.

→ We also see opportunities to secure elevated yields in US government and high-grade corporate bonds. As focus shifts from short-term inflation driven by higher oil prices to medium-term risks for growth and employment, these strategies are expected to outperform.

Bullish US equities – history shows elevated VIX levels followed by strong returns

Bullish US aerospace and defence equities – airline recovery, defence spending

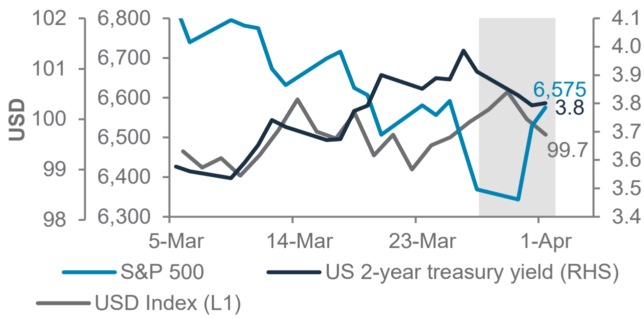
Bearish USD/JPY – JPY to benefit from BoJ rate hikes to counter inflation pressures

Important disclosures can be found in the Disclosures Appendix.

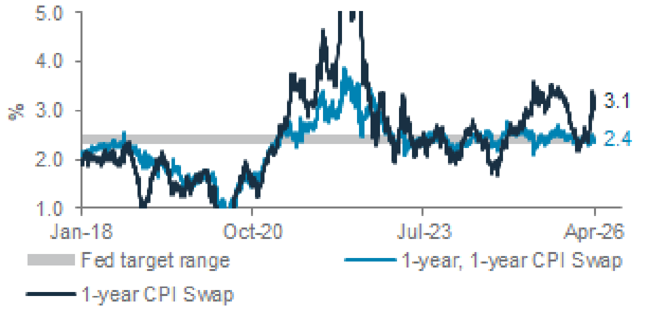
Charts of the week: Growth vs inflation concerns

Markets starting to price easing stagflation risks (see shaded area LHS) as long-term inflation expectations stay anchored

S&P500 index (up), US 2y yield (down), USD index (down)



US 1-year and 1y1y inflation expectations; Fed inflation target*



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; *2.3-2.5% inflation expectations based on CPI is consistent with the Fed's 2% PCE inflation target

Editorial

Inching towards a stalemate

Strategy summary: US President Trump's plan to end military operations in the Middle East within 2-3 weeks has eased fears of a drawn-out conflict. However, uncertainty remains about a near-term escalation in the conflict and when normal shipping through the Hormuz Strait will resume. Trump stated the responsibility for reopening the strait now falls to Asian and European governments, whose economies depend heavily on Gulf energy supplies. This signals tough negotiations ahead.

In this environment, we prefer investments in quality stocks with robust profit margins and earnings moats, especially within technology and utilities sectors. We also see opportunities to secure elevated yields in US government and high-grade corporate bonds. As focus shifts from short-term inflation driven by higher oil prices to medium-term risks for growth and employment, these strategies are expected to outperform.

Inching towards a stalemate: President Trump's intention to wind down Middle East military operations aligns with our base scenario of a brief conflict. Our 'pain indicator', which combines US equity and bond indices with presidential approval ratings, last week signalled a high likelihood of de-escalation after crossing a key threshold. However, reports of increased US troop deployments sustains the risk of renewed hostilities. The geopolitical situation therefore remains fluid, with escalation still possible, even as official statements lean towards resolution.

Demand for 'high moats': Amid heightened uncertainty, we prefer technology and utilities sectors that feature a concentration of high-quality stocks with strong margins and earnings. The US technology sector, in particular, offers attractive valuations. The recent market downturn has reduced the sector's forward price/earnings (P/E) premium to the S&P 500 index to below 5%, its lowest since January 2019 and down from a 35% premium in October 2025. Historical data shows that when the premium falls within the 4–6% range, returns over the next 3, 6, and 12 months have averaged 5%, 13%, and 19.7% respectively. The upcoming US Q2 corporate earnings season may support a recovery, especially if Middle East tensions ease. A diversified portfolio anchored by these sectors is expected to weather volatility and deliver strong medium-term performance.

Chance to lock in elevated bond yields: There are early signals policymakers and bond markets are starting to focus more on the conflict's impact on economic growth than on inflation. Fed Chair Powell stated this week that the central bank can look past a temporary spike in oil prices as long as inflation expectations are steady. This led to a retreat in the US 2-year government bond yield, which reacts to rate changes. The renewed emphasis on supporting growth strengthens our base case that the Fed will eventually cut rates in H2 to revive the job market. Locking in the currently elevated yields on high-quality bonds offers a favourable risk-reward trade-off.

Risk of a prolonged shutdown of Hormuz Strait: Even if the US withdraws its forces from the Middle East this month, Trump's proposal for Asia and Europe to negotiate with Iran about reopening Hormuz Strait traffic may result in protracted talks. Iran's parliament has passed legislation allowing the government to levy tolls on all vessels passing through the strait. With more than 80% of oil and gas shipped via the strait destined for Asian economies (China, India, Japan, South Korea), these nations must work with Iran and Gulf producers to establish a lasting transit agreement. Prediction markets currently give only a 14% chance that shipping traffic will return to normal by the end of April, reflecting ongoing uncertainty.

Hedging against risk of higher oil and gas prices: If the Hormuz Strait remains closed for long, energy prices are likely to rise. The strait normally accounts for c. 20% of global oil supply, but rerouting Saudi and UAE crude through alternative pipelines, releasing strategic reserves, and Iran's continued exports have temporarily cut the global shortfall to 8%. Still, without a quick resolution, oil prices are likely to rise as strategic reserves and floating stockpiles dwindle in a few weeks and supply struggles to match demand. To hedge against this risk, oil price-linked structured strategies, energy sector equities and US inflation-protected bonds remain prudent choices.

— **Rajat Bhattacharya**

The weekly macro balance sheet

Our weekly net assessment: On balance, we see the past week's data and policy as neutral for risk assets in the near-term

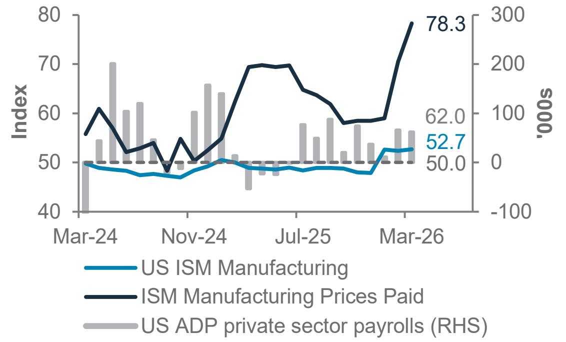
(+) factors: Resilient US manufacturing (mfg.) data and China activity; less hawkish Fed; likely easing of conflict

(-) factors: Weak US job data; likely BoJ hike; Hormuz strait uncertainty

	Positive for risk assets	Negative for risk assets
Macro data	• US ISM manufacturing PMI and Conference Board consumer confidence rose unexpectedly in March • US ADP private payrolls rose more than expected by 62,000 in March • Euro area headline and core consumer inflation rose less than expected • China mfg and non-mfg PMIs rose unexpectedly	• US ISM manufacturing prices paid index rose more than expected to 78.3 • US JOLTS job openings fell more than expected to 6.88m • Euro area economic confidence came in slightly below estimates • Euro area unemployment rate increased to 6.2%
	Our assessment: Neutral – Resilient US manufacturing and China activity data vs. weak US job openings, rising mfg. costs	
Policy developments	• Fed Chair Powell signalled no rate hike as long as long-term inflation expectations remain well-anchored • China's central bank signalled maintaining appropriately loose monetary policy	• Fed's Williams said monetary policy is well positioned amid uncertainty • BOJ's March meeting summary reflected a hawkish tilt, with debate on size of rate hike
	Our assessment: Neutral – Less hawkish Fed vs. potential BoJ hike	
Other developments	• President Trump, while warning of a near-term escalation in the Iran conflict, said the US could end the conflict in two-to-three weeks • Iran's president said Iran has necessary will to end conflict if guarantees prevent repeat attacks	• Trump said the US will leave it to other nations to negotiate free flow of Hormuz shipping traffic • US Secretary Rubio warned US may reassess NATO ties over lack of support during US-Iran conflict • China launched two trade investigations against the US, followed by probes initiated earlier by the US
	Our assessment: Neutral – Likely easing of Middle East conflict vs. Hormuz strait uncertainty	

US ISM manufacturing PMI strengthened in March, while the prices paid sub-index rose to the highest level since June 2022, signalling accelerating input cost inflation

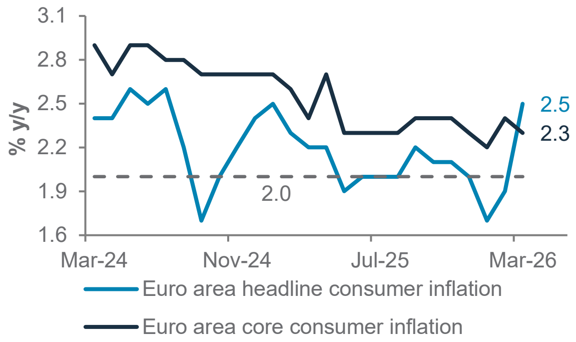
US ISM manufacturing and manufacturing prices paid indices, US ADP private sector payrolls



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Euro area headline inflation accelerated to 2.5% y/y in March, driven by a sharp rise in energy prices

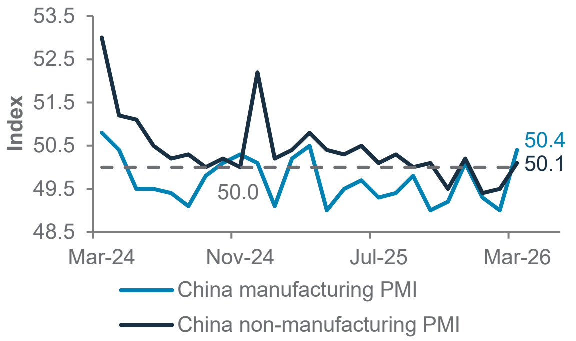
Euro area headline and core consumer inflation



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

China's factory activity growth returned to positive territory, with manufacturing and non-manufacturing PMIs rising above expectations

China manufacturing and non-manufacturing PMIs



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions

What are EU CPI and comments from Fed Chair Powell this week telling us about the likely ECB and Fed policy pathways?

Our view: Given our base-case view of a relatively short period of high oil prices, we expect the ECB to keep rates unchanged but hold a hawkish bias. We see the Fed resuming policy rate cuts in H2 2026 as it refocuses on labour-market weakness.

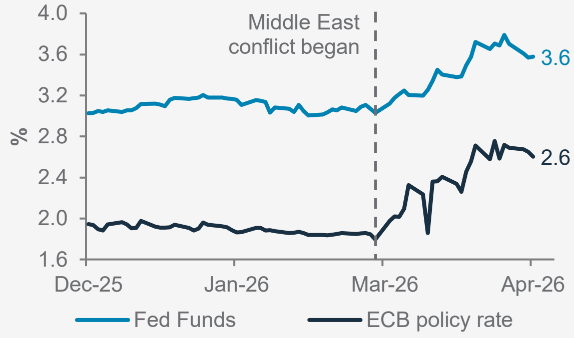
Rationale: The Eurostat flash estimate showed Euro area headline inflation rising to 2.5% y/y in March, from 1.9% in February. This increase was driven by a 4.9% surge in energy prices, directly linked to the Middle East conflict. While we anticipate the ECB will keep policy rates on hold through 2026, the key risk scenario is an extended conflict that keeps energy prices elevated for several months and pushes inflation towards 4%. Given a tight labour market, this could force the ECB to hike rates. That said, **any energy-price-driven inflation spike is likely to be self-limiting**, as it ultimately erodes disposable incomes and weighs on growth.

Meanwhile, in the US, Fed Chair Powell's 30 March remarks at Harvard noted that the Fed is in a "good place" to "wait and see" how the Iran crisis affects the economy and inflation. He said that **policymakers can "look through" temporary oil-price shocks**. This reinforces our view that the Fed will remain on hold in H1 2026, despite inflation remaining above target. We expect the Fed to resume policy rate cuts in H2 2026 as the Middle East conflict de-escalates and attention shifts back to labour-market weakness.

— **Ray Heung**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

Markets have repriced policy rate expectations higher in the US and the Euro area since the Middle East conflict began

Market-implied policy rates for the US and Euro area by year-end 2026



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

How would an extended Middle East conflict affect your Overweight views on Emerging Market (EM) government bonds and Developed Market High Yield (DM HY) bonds?

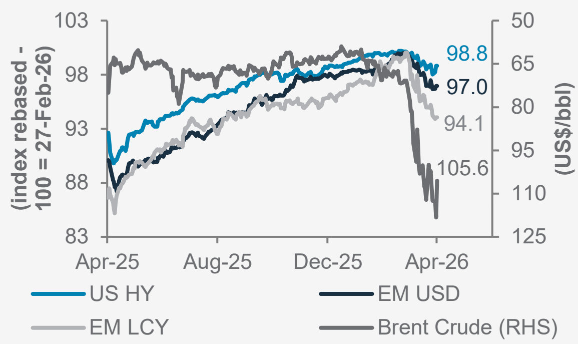
Our view: While not our base case, an extended Middle East conflict scenario would pose a downside risk to EM govt. bonds (both local-currency and USD) and DM HY corporate bonds.

Rationale: While not our base case, a prolonged Middle East conflict scenario would generate **higher inflationary pressures and slow global economic growth**. Higher commodity costs would strain external balances, currencies and fiscal positions in oil-importing EM economies. While individual EMs may still do well in this scenario, a broad EM overweight view would face downside risk. DM HY corporate bonds would face similar headwinds, as elevated energy costs compress margins (particularly in cyclical and consumer-facing sectors), raising default risks amid slowing growth. Although the energy sector may benefit, it represents less than 10% of the overall DM HY universe. In a risk-off environment, DM HY yield premium spreads would likely widen.

— **Ray Heung**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

EM USD & local currency (LCY) government bonds, US HY bonds have fallen since the onset of the Middle east conflict

Total index return of US HY corporate bonds and EM USD and LCY government bonds, rebased. Brent crude oil price (inverted)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

What drove US aerospace & defence (A&D) equity weakness? What are the key sector catalysts and risks?

Our view: A&D sector consolidation provides an opportunity to add amid supportive fundamentals.

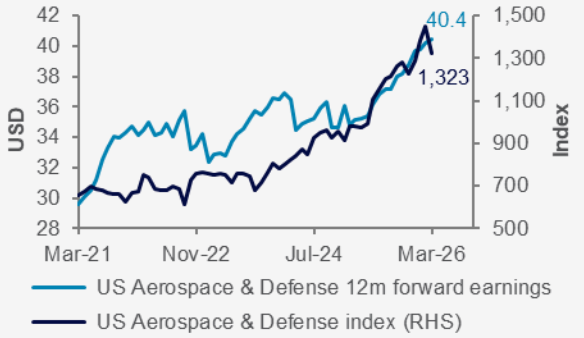
Rationale: The retreat in the A&D sector since March has been largely driven by three factors. First, the prolonged conflict has forced US airlines to **scale back Middle East operations**, a critical global transport hub routing approximately 30% of Asia-Europe air cargo. Second, the spike in oil prices is expected to **compress profit margins** across major airlines, as most US carriers have abandoned fuel hedging. Third, much of the short-term anticipated upside from rising military equipment demand linked to the Middle East conflict appears to have been priced in.

That said, we retain a positive view on the sector. Our base case remains for the conflict to de-escalate in a few weeks, supporting a recovery in commercial aerospace activity and easing oil prices. In addition, geopolitical developments since 2026 suggest a potential ramp-up in US diplomatic engagement ahead of the midterm elections and renewed focus on defence priorities. President Trump announced military spending of USD 1.5trn for 2027, a 50% increase from this year's budget. 12-month forward earnings growth of over 40% also provides a strong tailwind for a sustained sector recovery.

— **Michelle Kam, CFA**, *Investment Strategist*

Aerospace & Defence sector equities likely to gain, driven by solid earnings growth

US Aerospace & Defence Index and its 12-month forward earnings growth



Source: FactSet, Standard Chartered

Has Japan's recent soft data changed your Bank of Japan (BoJ) policy rate expectation? What is your view on USD/JPY?

Our view: Recent data has not altered our expectation that BoJ rates are likely to reach 1.25% by 2026 year-end. We remain bearish on USD/JPY.

Rationale: Tokyo's March inflation cooled slightly to 1.4% y/y, its slowest pace in nearly two years, driven primarily by a moderation in food costs. Consumer prices, excluding fresh food, rose by 1.7% y/y, marking the smallest increase since April 2024. However, the BoJ has indicated that this slowdown is likely temporary, with the Middle East conflict, in particular, posing inflationary risks. We see BoJ rates reaching 1.25% by year-end 2026.

Meanwhile, we expect USD weakness to resume, especially if President Trump indeed follows through on his comments to end the conflict soon. Additionally, US consumer confidence unexpectedly rose to 91.8 in March, from 91.0, but the measure of expectations for the next six months fell.

Technically, USD/JPY is forming a significant resistance zone at 160-161. We see the pair facing downside risk, with support at 155.9 (200-day moving average) in the coming week.

— **Iris Yuen**, *Investment Strategist*

USD/JPY is exposed to downside risk

USD/JPY and technicals

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Top client questions (cont'd)

How significant a risk is helium supply for the semiconductor sector? What are the likely catalysts for a turnaround in sector sentiment?

Our view: We see helium supply as a manageable risk in the near term. We remain positive on global semiconductors, driven by sustained AI capital expenditure (capex), which should be reiterated in the Q1 2026 earnings season.

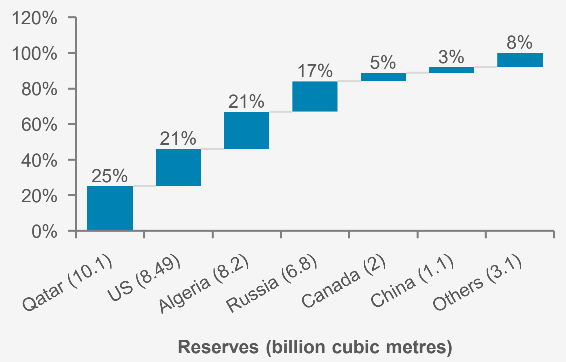
Rationale: Helium is essential in semiconductor manufacturing processes, primarily due to its cooling properties. The ongoing closure of the Strait of Hormuz is significantly disrupting global helium supply, given Qatar accounts for 25% of global reserves. Our supply-chain checks for the semiconductor industry suggest that there is sufficient inventory for about 3-6 months, limiting the risk of severe near-term disruptions. The most immediate impact is likely via price escalation. Helium accounts for about 0.3% of a semiconductor wafer's cost. During the Russia-Ukraine conflict, neon prices surged nearly 10x in early 2022, so a similar price spike in helium would erode profit margins for semiconductor producers.

A reopening of the Strait of Hormuz would be a positive catalyst for the chip industry, as supply chain concerns would ease. In addition, we expect the upcoming Q1 2026 earnings season to reiterate strong AI capex plans, which would be a fundamental catalyst for the semiconductor industry to move higher.

— **Fook Hien Yap**, *Senior Investment Strategist*

Qatar holds the largest reserve of helium globally, but we expect inventory levels to be sufficient to cope with near-term supply disruptions

Distribution of helium reserves globally



Source: USGS, Bloomberg Intelligence, Standard Chartered

How have US equities performed historically in the ensuing 12 months after the Volatility Index (VIX) hit 30, 40 and 50+?

Our view: The VIX closing above 30 signals market stress, but such episodes have historically been short-lived, preceding strong recoveries – with S&P500 forward 12-month returns averaging 29%, far above the 14% long-term average.

Rationale: The CBOE VIX closing above 30 last week rekindled market volatility concerns. Historically, the 30-level threshold signalled market dislocation; since 2016, the VIX has closed above 30 on around 6% of trading days, primarily during the 2020 pandemic and the 2022 inflationary drawdown. That said, it is important to note that such episodes of heightened uncertainty have historically proven short-lived, absent extreme macroeconomic conditions.

When the VIX closed above 30, the S&P500 has historically delivered average 12-month forward returns of 29%. This rises to 52% and 57% when the VIX surpasses 40 and 50, respectively – well above the unconditional 10-year average of 14%.

— **Jason Wong**, *Senior Equity Analyst*

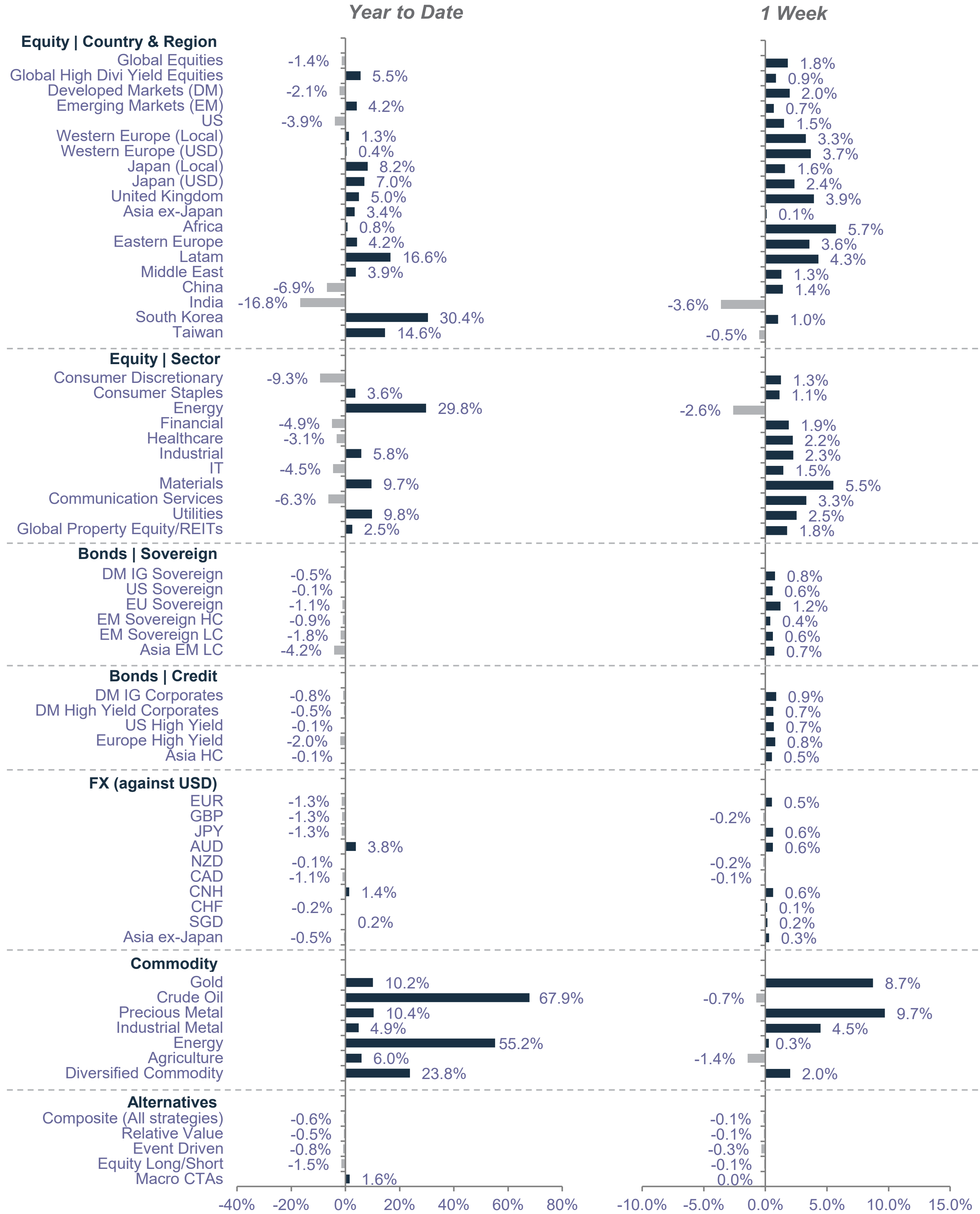
The S&P500 VIX index closing above the 30 level has historically been short-lived and has preceded strong recoveries

VIX and S&P500 Index 12-month forward return

	Number of days VIX closed> 30	S&P500 12m forward return
2016	0	–
2017	0	–
2018	5	22.0%
2019	0	–
2020	80	44.6%
2021	6	8.7%
2022	47	5.6%
2023	0	–
2024	1	21.5%
2025	12	–
2026	2	–
Since 2016	153	28.9%

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Market performance summary*



Sources: MSCI, JP Morgan, Barclays Capital, Citigroup, Dow Jones, HFRX, FTSE, Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

*Performance in USD terms unless otherwise stated, 2026 YTD performance from 31 December 2025 to 1 April 2026; 1-week period: 26 March 2026 to 1 April 2026

Our 12-month asset class views at a glance

Asset class			
Equities	▲	**Preferred Sectors**	
US	▲	US Technology	▲
Europe ex-UK	▼	US Healthcare	▲
UK	▼	US Utilities	▲
Asia ex-Japan	▲	Europe ex-UK Financials	▲
Japan	◆		
Other EM	◆	China Communication	▲
		China Technology	▲
Bonds	▼	China Healthcare	▲
Credit			
Asia USD	◆	**Alternatives**	◆
Corp DM HY	▲		
Govt EM USD	▲	**Gold**	▲
Corp DM IG	◆		
Govt			
Govt EM Local	▲		
Govt DM IG	▼		

Source: Standard Chartered Global Investment Committee

Legend: ▲ Most preferred | ▼ Less preferred | ◆ Core holding

Economic and market calendar

	Market	Event	Period	Expected	Prior
MON	USD	ISM Services Index	Mar	54.9	56.1
TUE	EUR	Sentix Investor Confidence	Apr	–	-3.1
	USD	Durable Goods Orders	Feb P	–	0.0%
WED	NZD	RBNZ Official Cash Rate	8-Apr	–	2.3%
	IND	RBI Repurchase Rate	8-Apr	–	5.3%
	EUR	PPI y/y	Feb	–	-2.1%
	EUR	Retail Sales y/y	Feb	–	2.0%
THU	USD	Personal Income	Feb	–	0.4%
	USD	PCE Price Index y/y	Feb	–	2.8%
	USD	Core PCE Price Index y/y	Feb	–	3.1%
	USD	GDP Annualized QoQ	4Q T	–	0.7%
FRI/SAT	CNH	PPI y/y	Mar	–	-0.9%
	CNH	CPI y/y	Mar	–	1.3%
	USD	CPI y/y	Mar	–	2.4%
	USD	Core CPI y/y	Mar	–	2.5%
	USD	U. of Mich. Sentiment	Apr P	–	53.3

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Prior data are for the preceding period unless otherwise indicated. Data are % change on previous period unless otherwise indicated
P - preliminary data, F - final data, sa - seasonally adjusted, y/y - year-on-year, m/m - month-on-month

The S&P500 has next interim resistance at 6,879

Technical indicators for key markets as of 1 Apr close

Index	Spot	1st support	1st resistance	12m forward P/E (x)	12m forward dividend yield (%)
S&P 500	6,575	6,294	6,879	19.6	1.3
STOXX 50	5,733	5,377	6,087	15.0	3.2
FTSE 100	10,365	9,720	10,960	13.2	3.5
TOPIX	3,671	3,446	3,897	16.8	2.4
Shanghai Comp	3,949	3,763	4,166	13.2	3.0
Hang Seng	25,294	24,197	26,397	10.9	3.4
Nifty 50	22,679	21,646	24,351	17.2	1.7
MSCI Asia ex-Japan	942	879	1,022	11.7	2.4
MSCI EM	1,458	1,363	1,576	11.2	2.9
Crude oil (WTI)	100.1	73.1	123.3	na	na
Gold	4,759	4,099	5,419	na	na
UST 10Y Yield	4.32	4.00	4.56	na	na

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Note: These short-term technical levels are based on models and may differ from a more qualitative analysis provided in other pages

Investor diversity has normalised across asset classes

Our proprietary market diversity indicators as of 1 Apr close

Level 1	Diversity	1-month trend	Fractal dimension
Global Bonds	●	↑	2.69
Global Equities	●	↑	1.76
Gold	●	↑	1.59
Equity			
MSCI US	●	→	1.56
MSCI Europe	●	↑	2.47
MSCI AC AXJ	●	↑	1.78
Fixed Income			
DM Corp Bond	●	↑	1.94
DM High Yield	●	↑	1.85
EM USD	●	↑	1.72
EM Local	●	↑	1.64
Asia USD	●	↑	2.17
Currencies			
EUR/USD	●	↑	1.61

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; **Fractal dimensions below 1.25 indicate extremely low market diversity/high risk of a reversal**

Legend: ● High | ◐ Low to mid | ○ Critically low

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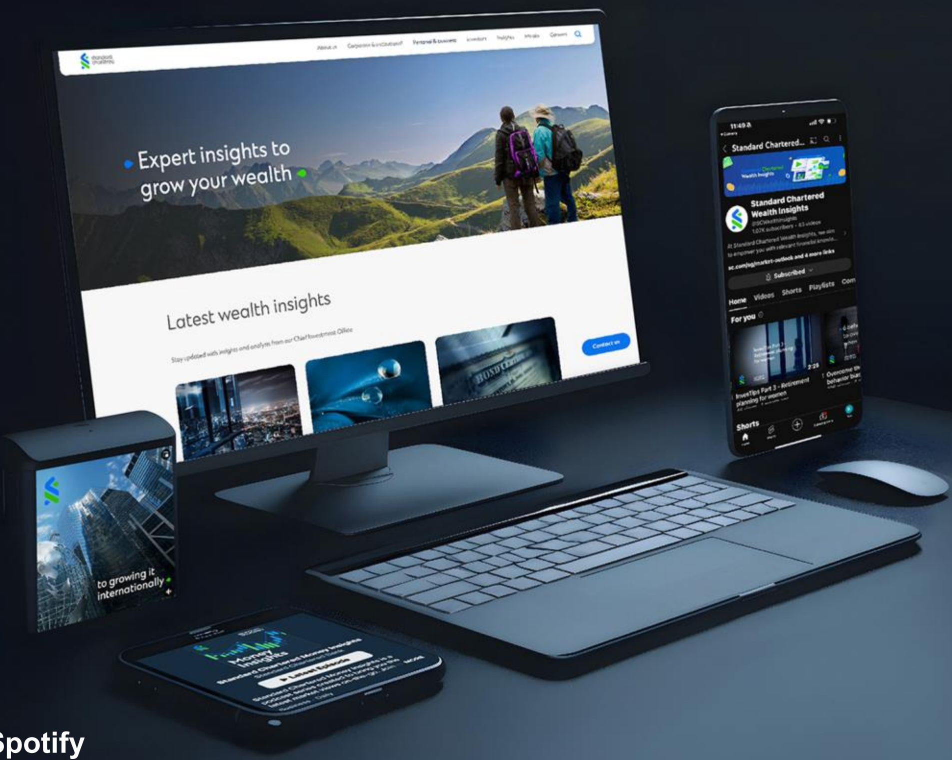

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